

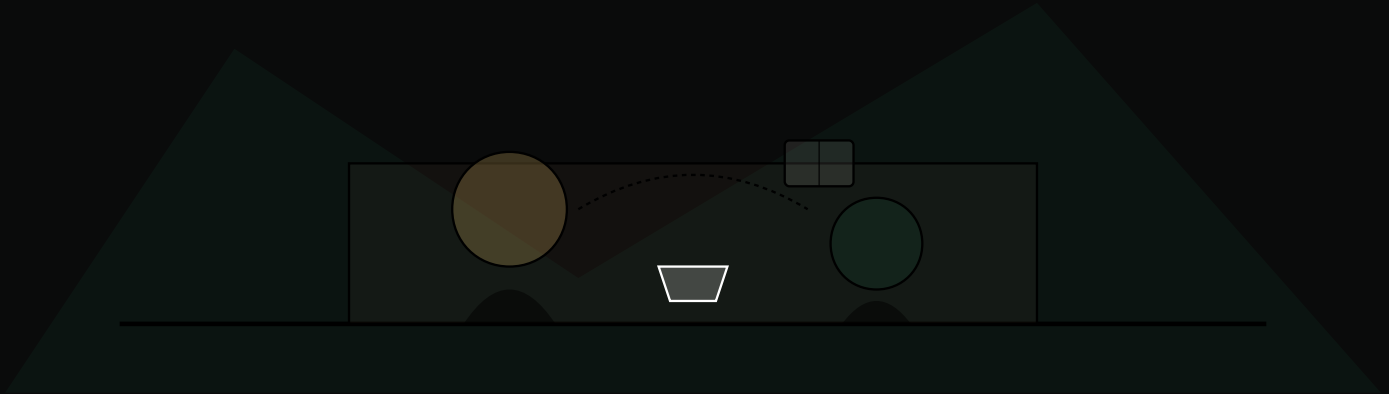
THE ROLE OF ELDERS

“Memory becomes guidance when one generation speaks to another.”

Every community has people who remember what others have forgotten. They remember names. They remember places. They remember families. They remember journeys, marriages, disputes, celebrations and losses. Sometimes they remember traditions that were never written down. These people are often the elders. In Orakzai society, as in many communities, elders can occupy an important place between generations. They may offer advice. They may preserve stories. They may welcome guests. They may help families resolve disagreements. They may represent community interests. And they may carry memories of a world that younger generations have never experienced. But respect for elders does not mean that every elder has the same authority, or that every memory is automatically historical fact. The role of an elder changes with family, village, education, migration, institutions and time. Understanding elders therefore means understanding both continuity and change.

THE ROLE OF ELDERS

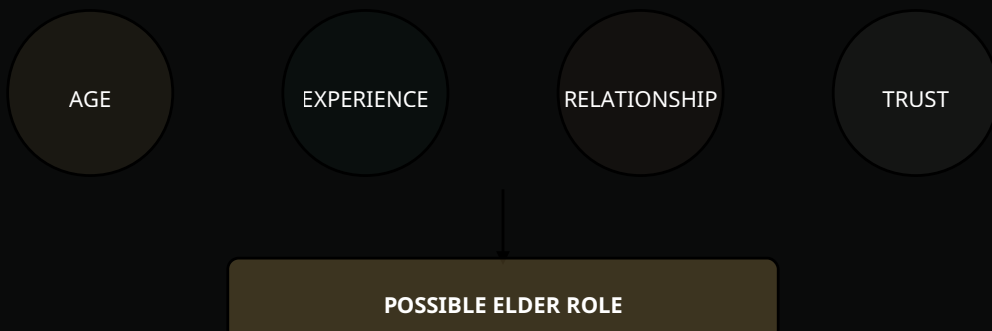
"Memory becomes guidance when one generation speaks to another."



"The intergenerational transmission of experience in Orakzai society."

WHO IS AN ELDER?

The term "elder" (*Mashar*) in Orakzai and Pashtun society is not a single uniform title. It encompasses several overlapping roles, from family patriarchs and matriarchs to community representatives and religious scholars. While age is the foundational requirement, true elderhood is defined by a combination of experience, relationship, and community trust. Age alone does not grant decision-making power; it is the wisdom derived from experience that commands respect.



“The components of social authority in elderhood.”

ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC

PASHTUN-WIDE

REGIONAL

FAMILY-SPECIFIC

CONTEMPORARY

SOCIAL COHESION AND LEADERSHIP

Elders are primary actors in promoting social cohesion within the Orakzai district. Research by J. Alam (2024) identifies them as "local supporters" who stabilize community relations during times of transition or crisis. This leadership is often expressed through the Malik institution—traditional representatives who manage tribal affairs and interface with state structures. In villages such as Mirbak, Maliks remain central to communal governance and representation.^{1,3}



“The role of traditional leadership in maintaining district stability.”

MEDIATION AND CONFLICT RESOLUTION

One of the most critical roles of elders is mediation. Through the Jirga—a collective assembly of *Masharan*—disputes are resolved through deliberation rather than unilateral command. This process focuses on reconciliation (*Nanawatai*) and the restoration of social balance. While customary processes have limitations, they provide a mechanism for resolving local disagreements that formal legal systems may not always reach.⁵

DISAGREEMENT

ELDER MEDIATION

(Jirga / Consultation)

AGREEMENT

“The workflow of communal conflict resolution.”

WOMEN AND ELDERHOOD

Elderhood is not exclusively a male domain. Elder women (*Grandmothers / Mothers*) hold significant authority within the household (*Kor*). Research by Noreen Naseer (2026) highlights their role as "early warning" systems for community safety, identifying tensions before they escalate. They are the primary transmitters of family history, lullabies, and domestic traditions to the next generation.²

Domestic Authority

Managing household affairs, family memory, and the upbringing of children.

Social Intelligence

Serving as community sensors and conflict preventers through informal networks.

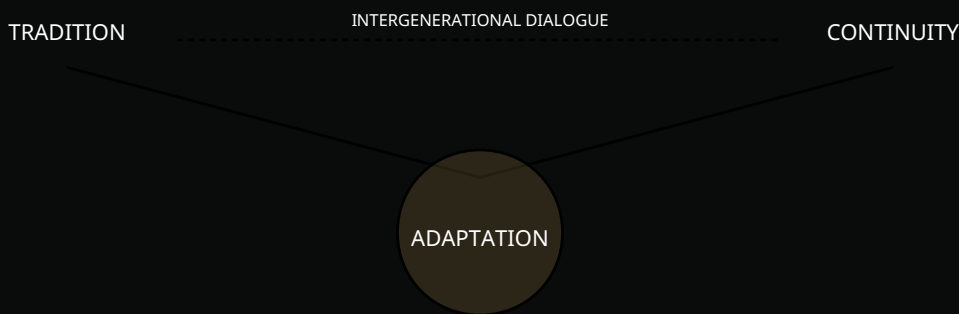
ELDER WOMEN

FAMILY MEMORY
LANGUAGE
SAFETY GUIDANCE

NEXT GENERATION

“The role of elder women in family and community resilience.”

The relationship between generations is changing. Education, technology, and migration have introduced new ways of knowing. Young people today may listen to their elders while also questioning and reinterpreting traditions through a modern lens. This is not necessarily a rejection of heritage but an adaptation. Continuity survives through the synthesis of ancient experience and modern access.



“The synthesis of tradition and modern questioning.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Respect for elders is a pillar of our society, but it is a pillar that must support the weight of the future as well as the past. In Orakzai, an elder's voice is a library of lived history—a record of the land before the roads, the families before the migration, and the values that have kept us together. But our responsibility as the younger generation is not just to obey; it is to listen, to record, and to understand. An elder's wisdom is a tool for navigation, not a fixed destination. By honoring our elders, we are not looking backward; we are ensuring that we have the guidance necessary to move forward with identity and purpose.

“EXPERIENCE IS THE ANCHOR OF WISDOM.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS

